

Russian sanctions season finale

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Presented by Google By GERARDO FORTUNA CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with a last-day-of-school vibe, marking the final College of Commissioners and

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CIAO THERE. Gerardo Fortuna back with a last-day-of-school vibe, marking the final College of Commissioners and — barring the need for an emergency encore (see below) — the last meeting of EU ambassadors before the summer.

START HERE: Ukraine President Volodymyr Zelenskyy fired top military commander Oleksandr Syrskyy last night, just days after ousting Defense Minister Mykhailo Fedorov — a move that sparked street protests. Veronika Melkozerova brings us the latest .

In today's Playbook:

- The EU is handing out grades on its social agenda. Who needs summer school?
- Gen Z takes over the Berlaymont today — with a list of demands.
- Faces in the crowd: Raffaele Fitto, Fidias Panayiotou, Kaja Kallas, María Ángela Holguín Cuéllar, Roxana Mînzatu, Caillum Hedderman, Monique Barbut, Guillaume Mercier, Marilena Raouna, Ditte Juul Jørgensen, Winston Peters, Loucas Fourlas and many more.

On today's Brussels Playbook Podcast: Zoya and Ian unpack the latest Russia sanctions stalemate.

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DRIVING THE DAY

LAST DRAMA OF THE SEASON: Ambassadors will meet today with an objective: a deal to impose restrictions on the shipping of Russian gas. But what are their chances of success before the summer break? No one knows.

Paging Kyriakos: Ambassadors who spoke to Playbook were despondent. “Very difficult to predict,” sighed one diplomat. Others simply replied: “Let’s see.” A third offered perhaps the most honest assessment of all: “Impossible to say. Better call Athens.”

All eyes on Greece: The country’s shipping industry wants provisions restricting the transport of Russian gas to third countries scrapped, arguing European companies would simply lose business to non-EU competitors. That’s why Athens remains the last holdout.

Problem won’t go away … Another delay on the 21st Russian sanctions package is the most-feared scenario. “If the issues haven’t been resolved now, when will they?” one EU diplomat wondered. “You can postpone again, but you’ll just come back to the same problems.”

… and the clock is ticking: Oil markets are moving , geopolitical tensions are mounting, and the pressure to finally wrap up the package — which is linked to the bloc’s price cap on Russian crude — is growing. Wasn’t the imposition of sanctions supposed to have become easier in the post-Orbán era?

Getting 27 capitals to agree will only get harder. “There’s no more low-hanging fruit after 20 packages,” one EU diplomat told my colleague Koen Verhelst. Indeed, Monday’s meeting of the diplomats who prepare the work for EU ambassadors (known as Anticis) didn’t solve the standoff (Playbook unpacked the issue earlier this week).

Previously, on sanctions … the top diplomats burned through three days of negotiations last week without reaching agreement on what is still considered a hefty package. There are about 250 new listings, more banks, more shadow-fleet vessels and fresh measures targeting Russia’s war machine.

A familiar script: Coreper II — the meeting of EU ambassadors — kicks off at 10 a.m. The day is expected to unfold much like last week, according to three EU diplomats with knowledge of the plans. That means an initial discussion with sanctions as the first agenda item, followed by a break covering other topics, before ambassadors return later in the day.

Austria unresolved: Vienna dropped its veto to the sanctions last week, despite EU members rejecting Austria’s request to compensate Raiffeisen Bank for the €2.1 billion in assets seized by Russia, two EU diplomats familiar with the discussions told my colleague Gregorio Sorgi. In classic Brussels fashion, capitals promised to come back to it later.

HOT POTATO 2 — ISRAELI SETTLEMENTS: Russia sanctions aren’t the only politically charged file on ambassadors’ desks today. Hidden behind the bland-sounding “Follow-up on FAC” agenda item: possible trade restrictions on products from illegal Israeli settlements.

From ministers to ambassadors: One diplomat described last week’s ministers’ discussion as “quite short” and “inconclusive,” prompting top diplomat Kaja Kallas to send the file back to Coreper to figure out what capitals could actually live with before it returns to ministers.

Cancel your vacation: Last week, Kallas floated the idea of an extraordinary meeting of foreign affairs ministers on the issue, and one EU official told Playbook the option to have it even in the heat of summer remains … open.

BIG AND BREAKING

GENERIC DRUG TARIFFS: U.S. President Donald Trump has announced a plan to impose a 100 percent tariff on generic drugs starting in August 2028, as part of a bid to push pharmaceutical production back

to the U.S. If implemented, the tariff would then jump to 200 percent in 2029, Trump said in an overnight social media post .

THE COST OF WAR: U.S. Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth has told a Senate committee the military conflict against Iran has cost about \$37.5 billion over the past five months . Hegseth declined to say when the war might end.

NO BIENNALE BAILOUT: The Commission's cultural agency is pulling a €2 million grant from the Venice Biennale because Russia will take part in the 2026 edition. "Cultural events funded by European taxpayers' money should safeguard democratic values [that] are not respected in today's Russia," Commission spokesperson Guillaume Mercier told Mari Eccles.

AI GOES TO EU CO: António Costa wants leaders to finally have the AI conversation. The Council president's office confirmed to POLITICO's Pieter Haeck that a dedicated debate is penciled in for one of the EU's remaining summits this year — October, November or December.

KYIV'S MESSAGE TO THE IOC: Lifting the ban on Russian athletes would only help Russian President Vladimir Putin, Ukraine warns the International Olympic Committee .

MACRON TO LOSE ANOTHER MINISTER: French Ecological Transition Minister Monique Barbut plans to resign after parliament approved contentious farming legislation that laid bare fresh cracks in the president's coalition. Victor Goury-Laffont and Élisabeth Bertholomé have the inside story .

SOCIAL REPORT CARDS ARE IN

MARKING COUNTRIES' SOCIAL HOMEWORK: Governments will find out today how delivery of the Commission's goals to increase employment, sharply boost adult participation in training and reduce poverty remains patchy, Zoya Sheftalovich reports.

So long: The College of Commissioners meets for the last time before the summer, and the top only item on the agenda is an assessment, to be unveiled by Executive Vice President Roxana Mînzatu, of how countries are delivering on what's known as the European Pillar of Social Rights.

What is it? The Pillar, agreed in 2017, sets out 20 principles covering access to jobs and skills, fair working conditions and social protection. A 2021 action plan translated those principles into 75 initiatives and set three headline targets for 2030.

Must do better: Brussels has now presented all 75 initiatives. But progress is uneven, according to a Commission official. The EU employment rate reached 76.3 percent in early 2026, putting the bloc within striking distance of its 78 percent target. But progress on skills is far weaker, with just 39.5 percent of adults taking part in learning each year, against a 60 percent goal. Only 60 percent of Europeans have basic digital skills. The target is 80 percent.

What comes next: The Commission will identify where Europe is falling behind and set priorities for the next phase, with greater emphasis on measurable results and the social agenda beyond 2030. It comes alongside work on a possible Quality Jobs Act, which could cover training, working conditions and the growing use of algorithmic management systems. Mînzatu has also previously floated an EU tool to help people who are willing and able to work but remain outside the labor market.

Reality check: The bigger question is how much Brussels can achieve without stronger national implementation. The Commission argues Europe must manage rapid labor-market change, including the impact of AI, while maintaining social protection — but much of the responsibility still rests with member countries.

SECURITY COLLEGE RETURNS: Social rights isn't the only topic for today's College meeting. Commissioners will also switch into Security College format to discuss Ukraine and the EU's eastern border, a Commission spokesperson told Playbook.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The European Parliament hasn't quite finished its work before the summer break and this week is a "pink week" for MEPs. What does that mean? The Parliament's calendar is color-coded: red weeks are plenary sessions (when all MEPs meet in Strasbourg or Brussels to debate, amend, and vote on legislation); pink weeks are when MEPs meet in their specific committees to discuss draft legislation and prepare reports; blue weeks are when the political groups meet up for discussions; and green weeks are for work outside the Parliament, including going back to their constituency or on a work trip.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: On the Brussels Playbook Podcast, Ian asked for the most common misconceptions about your country in Hollywood cinema. Whatsapp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shoutout.

THE RIGHT FIT FOR CYPRUS?

FITTO HITS THE CYPRUS FILE: Less than a week after being named the European Commission's Special Representative for Cyprus, Executive Vice President Raffaele Fitto is wearing his new hat. Today he'll meet María Ángela Holguín Cuéllar, the U.N. Secretary-General's personal envoy to the country.

Mission briefing: The goal is — no pressure! — to start laying the groundwork for the reunification of the island, split for more than 50 years between the Republic of Cyprus in the south and the Turkish-controlled north. Fitto is helping prepare the conditions for negotiations on a "comprehensive and lasting solution," the Commission's Guillaume Mercier told Playbook.

Why now? Because someone has to try. Brussels hopes Fitto's appointment can breathe new life into reunification talks that have gone nowhere for years. Optimism hasn't entirely disappeared: Cyprus EU affairs minister Marilena Raouna said last week she still "believes in reunification."

The EU remains "firmly committed" to that goal within the U.N.-led framework, Mercier said, meaning Fitto and Holguín will need to work hand in hand.

"It's still soon to say if Fitto is the right fit," MEP and influencer Fidias Panayiotou — arguably the best-known Cypriot in Brussels — told Playbook. One thing he does like: the job has gone to one of the Commission's executive vice presidents, signaling the bloc is taking the issue seriously.

Watched closely: While calling the new appointment "an important opportunity" and welcoming "every sincere effort" to restart negotiations, fellow Cypriot MEP Loucas Fourlas warned Fitto's job "cannot be limited to seeking arrangements that primarily accommodate Ankara's demands in exchange for progress in EU-[Turkey] relations."

DASHBOARD

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

MERGER WEDNESDAY: Three major merger rulings land today — with implications for Hollywood, Big Oil and the video-game industry. More on Morning Fair Play (for subscribers).

OH, CAP! Europe's farm subsidies are making fruit and vegetables more expensive, according to a U.N. report, undermining efforts to make healthy food more affordable.

BREAKFAST AT TURNBERRY'S: The EU's top trade official Ditte Juul Jørgensen will debrief the bloc's 27 envoys on EU-U.S. trade relations over breakfast this morning, with Washington's temporary tariffs expiring in just a couple of days. More on the meeting on Morning Trade (for subscribers).

SHOW YOUR BOOKS: A federal judge has ruled that U.S. President Donald Trump has to turn over detailed financial information in connection with his defamation lawsuit against the BBC.

NEW PARTY TO TAKE ON ERDOĞAN: Turkey's deposed opposition leader Özgür Özel has said he's establishing a new political party to challenge President Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, the FT reports.

DG CONNECT'S GROWTH: The Commission's tech department has never been bigger. It has reached a record staffing level as it gears up to enforce the bloc's ever-growing digital rulebook. More on Morning Tech (for subscribers).

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Cloudy, chance of rain. Top of 21C.

KIDS' COUP: The average age around Schuman is set to plummet today, as Ursula von der Leyen summons her youth whisperers. The European Commission president hosts the second meeting of her Youth Advisory Board, bringing together representatives from national youth councils across the EU, the Western Balkans, Ukraine and Moldova.

What is it? The board was set up last year under the Commission's Youth Strategy as a way to give young people a direct line into Brussels. Since its first meeting in December, members have fed into discussions on issues ranging from youth participation to online safety — including the Commission's work on protecting minors online.

Face time: Playbook spoke with Caillum Hedderman, president of the European Youth Forum, who will be sitting down with von der Leyen. Getting direct access to the Commission chief is significant, he said (cue the envy of bubble hacks).

What young people want: A youth-proofed EU budget, starting with more money for Erasmus+, Hedderman said ("Just 15 percent of young Europeans are reached by Erasmus+, according to the Draghi report. It's an unfinished story"). And stronger backing for youth organizations. "Investing in young people isn't a trade-off," he said. "It's the most important thing the EU can do."

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Germany's relationship with Nigeria is struggling to get off the ground. Foreign Minister Johann Wadephul is determined to change that .

London: Andy Burnham and Wes Streeting are on the same team now. And they'll have reasons to be pleased with the perks of office they'll soon get to enjoy.

Paris: Monique Barbut's list of grievances is long — too long for her to want to remain as France's ecological transition minister.

Washington PM: Service members have been killed in Jordan and Iraq over the last week and the Pentagon is running out of cash. But Donald Trump is charging ahead .

AGENDA

- High Representative Vice President Kaja Kallas is in the Philippines where she'll be meeting Timor-Leste's minister of foreign affairs Bendito dos Santos Freitas, Pakistan Foreign Minister Mohammad Ishaq Dar, New Zealand Foreign Minister Winston Peters. Kallas co-chairs the ASEAN Post-Ministerial Conference.
- Economy Commissioner Valdis Dombrovskis attends the ECB Governing Council.
- Commission Executive Vice-President Raffaele Fitto meets with María Ángela Holguín Cuéllar, the United Nations secretary-general's personal envoy on Cyprus.
- Commission President Ursula von der Leyen hosts the President's Youth Advisory Board. Commissioner for Intergenerational Fairness Glenn Micallef participates.
- Weekly College of Commissioners and Security College meeting.
- EU Council Coreper I at 9 a.m. in Brussels.
- EU Council Coreper II at 10 a.m. in Brussels.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Nora Mebarek and Harald Vilimsky; Pieter De Crem, former Belgian defense minister; former U.S. Ambassador to NATO Kay Bailey Hutchison; College of Europe's former rector Jörg Monar; former President of the Maine-et-Loire Department Council Christian Gillet; PM of Jamaica Andrew Holness; U.K.'s Prince George.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Ferdinand Knapp and Milena Wälde, editor James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

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